



Direct-to-Home Services

DTH services in India really matured this year. Last year, we had started to see a couple of channels in HD such as National Geographic HD and Discovery HD World. This year, DTH service providers went all out to woo customers with their HD goodies. With set-top boxes having HD recording facilities on board, it was a battle of which service provided maximum HD channels and longer hours of recording.

But this HD war also prompted certain DTH players such as Dish TV and Reliance Digital TV to make false claims over the number of true HD channels they could provide. Dish TV advertised its 45 HD channels with star ambassadors. Technically they were beaming 1080i content, but it was all upscaled content. In our exhaustive testing we cleared these doubts. Even Reliance claimed to have 250 channels in its bouquet with "HD like quality"! That's the most ridiculous tagline one could ever use, isn't it?

Always remember, true HD content is that which is actually shot in HD and transmitted as HD. By that definition there are only Discovery HD World, National Geographic HD, Movies Now, ESPN HD, Star Cricket HD, Star Plus HD, Star Movies HD, Star World HD, Star Gold HD, Travel XP HD and iConcerts HD channels that are true high-definition. Don't fall for tall claims of 50 or 250 HD channels.

Zero1 Winner

TataSky+ HD

TataSky+ HD is the winner of the Zero1 Award this year as its overall feature set and performance trounced its competition. It has one of the most intuitive and responsive user interface, and doesn't require a steep learning curve. The biggest bane of this provider, specially for football fans, was the absence of the Ten Sports bouquet, but was added after our comparison test. Also, since our test in May, TataSky has come out with an iPhone app along with an option to use your phone as a remote by plugging in a mobile infrared accessory in the phone's 3.5mm audio jack. TataSky has also introduced catch-up TV which allows you to download all the shows that you may have missed



TataSky+ HD

Price: ₹4,899*

out on or not kept on record. All this for free. As a DVR, the TataSky+ HD scored much higher than its competitors.

Worthy Mentions

Videocon d2h 3D HD DVR

Videocon d2h 3D HD DVR is the other feature-rich HD recorder which also boasts of being India's only 3D HD set-top box. Actually, TataSky+ also has an HDMI 1.4a standard cable, which is required to transmit 3D content. But as there's hardly any 3D content being produced in India, or being broadcast for that matter and add to the fact that the 3D TV marketing blitzkrieg has given way to that of Smart TVs, we don't think 3D support in your set-top box will add any value for now. But Videocon d2h is the only service currently offering the highest number of true HD channels.



Videocon d2h 3D HD DVR

Price: ₹4,950*



Airtel Digital TV HD Recorder

Price: ₹4,790*

Airtel Digital TV HD Recorder

The value DTH service provider in the country has to be Airtel Digital TV HD, with economical cost of ownership for a year and a decent bouquet of HD channels thrown in, this is the service you should go for if your budget is limited. Also features such as controlling recording mechanism from your Airtel-enabled cellphone is an added incentive for the professional on the move.

*Price includes cost of set-top box and installation charges